

STATE OF OKLAHOMA

2nd Session of the 60th Legislature (2026)

COMMITTEE SUBSTITUTE
FOR ENGROSSED
SENATE BILL NO. 1546

By: Pugh of the Senate

and

Caldwell (Chad) of the
House

COMMITTEE SUBSTITUTE

An Act relating to teachers; amending 70 O.S. 2021, Section 698.1, as last amended by Section 1, Chapter 249, O.S.L. 2023 (70 O.S. Supp. 2025, Section 698.1), which relates to the Inspire to Teach Program; renaming the program; increasing scholarship amounts available for eligible students; updating statutory language; providing an effective date; and declaring an emergency.

BE IT ENACTED BY THE PEOPLE OF THE STATE OF OKLAHOMA:

SECTION 1. AMENDATORY 70 O.S. 2021, Section 698.1, as last amended by Section 1, Chapter 249, O.S.L. 2023 (70 O.S. Supp. 2025, Section 698.1), is amended to read as follows:

Section 698.1. A. The Oklahoma State Regents for Higher Education shall establish and maintain an incentive scholarship program and teacher employment incentive program, as funding is available through appropriations or private donations, to encourage the preparation of public school teachers for prekindergarten

1 through twelfth grade, including minority teachers, at all ~~state~~
2 ~~public higher education~~ institutions of higher education within The
3 Oklahoma State System of Higher Education or private higher
4 education institutions accredited pursuant to Section 4103 of this
5 title and incentivize employment as public school teachers for
6 prekindergarten through twelfth grade in the state for at least five
7 (5) years, to be known as the ~~Inspired to Teach Program~~ New
8 Educators for Excellence in Teaching and Education (NEXT-ED)
9 Program. Prospective teachers planning to pursue an undergraduate
10 teacher education program at an accredited ~~Oklahoma~~ teacher
11 preparation program in this state shall be considered if they
12 graduated from high school, completed high-school level instruction
13 at home, or completed General Educational Development (GED) test
14 requirements; meet the ~~higher education~~ admission standards of the
15 institution of higher education; and declare a pre-education major
16 or major in an approved ~~Oklahoma~~ teacher preparation degree program
17 in this state leading to a standard teaching certificate.

18 B. To the extent that funds are available, scholarships,
19 renewable for up to three (3) additional years for qualified
20 students meeting satisfactory academic progress standards in
21 completing a teacher preparation degree program leading to a
22 standard teaching certificate, shall be awarded to cover costs of
23 tuition, general enrollment and other fees, ~~other fees~~, books,
24

1 materials, and services provided by the institution, including room
2 and board, in the following manner:

3 1. One Thousand Dollars (\$1,000.00) per academic year for up to
4 three (3) academic years for full-time students who have earned ~~less~~
5 fewer than ninety (90) credit hours; and

6 2. Two Thousand Five Hundred Dollars (\$2,500.00) for the final
7 academic year for full-time students who have earned ninety (90) or
8 more credit hours.

9 The maximum amount of scholarship funds awarded as provided in this
10 subsection to any qualified student shall not exceed Five Thousand
11 Five Hundred Dollars (\$5,500.00).

12 C. As used in this section, "full-time student" means:

13 1. An undergraduate student enrolled in twelve (12) or more
14 semester credits toward teacher education degree requirements;

15 2. An undergraduate student who is a teacher education major
16 who is enrolled in or has completed an internship or student
17 teaching credit hours in order to complete the degree program prior
18 to certification and who has been approved to take ~~less~~ fewer than
19 twelve (12) credit hours; or

20 3. An undergraduate student who is a teacher education major
21 with an approved reasonable accommodation from ~~Student Accessibility~~
22 ~~Services~~ student accessibility services at the institution due to a
23 documented disability and who has been approved to take ~~less~~ fewer
24 than twelve (12) credit hours.

1 D. It is the intent of the ~~Oklahoma~~ Legislature that the
2 Oklahoma State Regents for Higher Education create a committee
3 composed of educators, teacher educators from the participating
4 institutions, and representatives of the public schools in this
5 state and the State Department of Education to provide
6 recommendations to the State Regents to improve effectiveness of the
7 ~~Inspired to Teach Program~~ NEXT-ED Program. The committee shall
8 prepare and electronically deliver a report on the program to the
9 Legislature on or before July 1 of each year.

10 E. Each scholarship participant, prior to entry into the
11 ~~Inspired to Teach Program~~ NEXT-ED Program, shall have agreed to
12 teach in ~~an Oklahoma~~ a public prekindergarten through twelfth grade
13 school in this state for a minimum of five (5) consecutive years
14 upon graduation and licensure as a teacher. Any scholarship
15 participant failing to maintain a 2.5 grade point average throughout
16 matriculation, changing to an ineligible area of study, failing to
17 meet satisfactory academic progress standards, withdrawing or
18 otherwise leaving school, or failing to meet requirements for
19 licensure and certification to teach as established by law shall be
20 subject to disqualification from the program.

21 F. The Oklahoma State Regents for Higher Education are
22 authorized to make employment incentive payments pursuant to the
23 provisions of this section to ~~Inspired to Teach Program~~ NEXT-ED
24 Program participants who are employed as traditionally certified

1 teachers in ~~Oklahoma~~ public prekindergarten through twelfth grade
2 schools in this state following graduation. Incentive payments may
3 be awarded following each consecutive year of satisfactory service
4 as documented by the employing school district, up to five (5) years
5 of service for scholarship recipients as provided in subsection A of
6 this section, upon graduation from an accredited ~~Oklahoma~~ teacher
7 preparation degree program in this state. The maximum amount of
8 employment incentive payments for any qualified participant shall be
9 Four Thousand Dollars (\$4,000.00) per year for up to five (5) years,
10 not to exceed a total of Twenty Thousand Dollars (\$20,000.00) per
11 participant.

12 G. The Oklahoma State Regents for Higher Education shall
13 require the execution of appropriate contracts with eligible
14 ~~Inspired to Teach Program~~ NEXT-ED Program participants.

15 Participants failing to comply with the requirements of this section
16 or failing to provide current contact information shall not be
17 eligible for the employment incentive payments provided for in this
18 section. The Chancellor of the Oklahoma State Regents for Higher
19 Education, with the approval of the State Regents, may contract with
20 any other appropriate organization or unit of government for the
21 administration of the provisions of this section.

22 H. If sufficient funds are not available for employment
23 incentive payments to qualified participants during any fiscal year,
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1 the Chancellor may make reductions in the payments made to qualified
2 participants.

3 I. The Oklahoma State Regents for Higher Education may, at the
4 time an award is made on behalf of the ~~Inspired to Teach Program~~
5 NEXT-ED Program, set aside funds for the full commitment made to an
6 eligible student.

7 J. The Oklahoma State Regents for Higher Education may utilize
8 ~~Inspired to Teach Program~~ NEXT-ED Program designated funds for
9 administration of the program.

10 SECTION 2. This act shall become effective July 1, 2026.

11 SECTION 3. It being immediately necessary for the preservation
12 of the public peace, health, or safety, an emergency is hereby
13 declared to exist, by reason whereof this act shall take effect and
14 be in full force from and after its passage and approval.

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